

between 1963 and 1971 and together constitute over a quarter of the population in this age group. In a sense, they are different from those who are employed or engaged in home duties or still at school, in that they are not directly engaged in any purposeful activity. The increase in the "other" category when viewed together with the decreases recorded in the proportions engaged in studies and home duties is indicative of a movement of young persons away from these latter activities towards the labour force.

Adults - The adults aged 20-59 years form the most important and stable component of the labour force. This age group which forms less than one half of the total population supplies over 80 percent of the labour force. Table 9.7 presents the distribution by activity of all persons in this age group. About 55 percent are in the labour force and another 30 percent, almost all of them women, are attending to home duties. Only the balance 5 percent are in other categories such as students, income recipients and others voluntarily not available for work. It is thus clear that the 20-59 age group constitutes the working age span of the people of Sri Lanka.

TABLE 9.7 : PERCENTAGE DISTRIBUTION BY ACTIVITY OF ADULT PERSONS AGED 20-59, 1971

	Employed	Unemployed	Students	Engaged in home duties	Others	Total
T	54.9	10.5	1.4	29.5	3.8	100
M	82.7	11.1	1.5	1.1	3.6	100
F	25.0	9.8	1.3	59.8	3.9	100

In the case of the males, 94 percent are in the labour force, this proportion remaining more or less constant in all four census years from 1946 to 1971. However, the age-specific rates show that the activity rates of the two extreme age groups viz. 20-24 years and 55-59 years had been subject to larger variations, with an increasing trend in the case of 20-24 age group and a decreasing trend in the case of those aged 55-59 years. The younger age groups being much larger in size, the changes in their rates have greater effect on overall activity rates than those relating to the older groups.

In the case of the females, the age group 20-59 as a whole had recorded substantial increases in the activity rate from 28.6 percent in 1946 to 34.9 percent in 1971, while the proportion of the labour force in this age group has increased from 71.8 percent to 79.8 during the same period. An examination of the age-specific activity rates shows that this has been due to an increasing trend in the rates for those in the 20-39 age group and a decreasing trend in the rates of those aged 40-59 years. While it may be expected that the activity rate in the younger ages would increase with more and more women seeking employment, the phenomenon of women leaving the labour force as early as in their forties in sufficiently large numbers to bring about a declining trend in the activity rates for those age groups is somewhat unexpected in the socio-economic context of the country.